Beware of Philosophy

Believers must beware of any man-made philosophy that is not according to Christ, because all the fullness of Deity dwells in Him bodily, they are complete in Him, and He has forgiven them, canceled their debt and triumphed over every hostile power.

Where this study fits

Colossians · twelve studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–8 **Faith, Love, and Hope in Colossae**	**02 1:9–14** **Paul's Prayer for the Colossians**	**03 1:15–23** **The Savior of the Gospel**	**04 1:24–29** **Christ in You, the Hope of Glory**
05 2:1–7 **The Believer's Education**	**06 2:8–15** **Beware of Philosophy**	**07 2:16–23** **Run the Race Set Before You**	**08 3:1–11** **Looking Up, Putting Off**
09 3:12–17 **Service Manual for the Lord's Army**	**10 3:18–4:1** **The Relationships of the New Man**	**11 4:2–6** **Perfecting the Prayer Life**	**12 4:7–18** **Portrait of a Ministry Team**

Four marks of the philosophy

Colossians 2:8 · Outline I — Beware of philosophy

A It is deceptive

κενός · ἀπάτη
“Empty deception” — it looks full, but it is hollow and meant to mislead

B It is man-made

“The tradition of men” — borrowing some biblical truth to make error palatable (cf. Mark 7)

C It is worldly

στοιχεῖα
“Elementary principles of the world” — the ABCs; rudimentary rules or elemental spirits

D It is not according to Christ

Christ was in their system — but not enough. Anything not according to Him is against Him

“Takes you captive” — συλαγωγέω, to carry off as booty. Not harmless extras, but kidnapping.

Be aware of Christ

Colossians 2:9–10 · Outline II.A–D

A **His deity · v.9a**

θεότης theotēs · only here
“All the fullness of Deity” — the very essence of God, nothing left out; shuts the door on kenosis

B **His humanity · v.9b**

σωματικῶς
“In bodily form” — a real human body: fully God and fully man, one Person

C **Our sufficiency · v.10a**

πληρόω periphrastic perfect
“Made complete” — same root as plērōma: made full, and remaining full

D **His headship · v.10b**

“Head over all rule and authority” — no chain of angelic mediators needed

He is the fullness of God, and you have been made full in Him. Live from fullness, not toward it.

Behold your share in Christ

Colossians 2:11–14 · Outline III.A–D

v.11	Circumcision without hands — spiritual, entire (“the body of the flesh”), by Christ	**ἀχειροποίητος** not made by hand
v.12	Buried and raised with Him — Spirit baptism (1 Cor 12:13), pictured by water baptism	**συνθάπτω** buried together with (Rom 6:4)
v.13a	Past condition: dead in transgressions and the uncircumcision of your flesh	**—** cf. Eph 2:1–3
v.13b	Present position: made alive together with Him, having forgiven us all our transgressions	**συζωοποιέω · χαρίζομαι** made alive · forgiven as a favor
v.14	The certificate of debt canceled, taken out of the way, nailed to the cross	**χειρόγραφον** a signed IOU

What God did with the debt

Colossians 2:14 · Outline III.D — The debt canceled

The IOU	Canceled	Taken away	Nailed to the cross
χειρόγραφον A handwritten acknowledgment of debt — “decrees against us, hostile to us”	Wiped clean, like a writing surface	Perfect tense — removed, and it stays removed	**προσηλόω** Like the charge posted over the crucified (John 19:19)
v.14a	v.14b	v.14c	v.14d

Paid in full at the cross. Nothing remains to be paid to obtain — or to keep — salvation.

The fate of the powers

Colossians 2:15 · Outline IV — Be awake to the fate of the powers

Disarmed	Displayed	Triumphed over
ἀπεκδύομαι Stripped like a defeated soldier of his armor and weapons	Paraded publicly, as captives behind a Roman general	**θριαμβεύω** Led in triumphal procession — doom sealed for all evil
v.15a	v.15b	v.15c

Believers have nothing more to fear from signs, charms or unseen powers. Christ has triumphed over them all.

Discuss and apply

Colossians 2:8–15 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. If believers are “made complete” in Christ (v.10), what does that mean for any teaching that offers something more?

2. How does the picture of the certificate of debt nailed to the cross bring assurance to a believer?

Apply

Live from Fullness, Not Toward It
Memorize Colossians 2:9–10 and recite it whenever you feel spiritually inadequate.

Remember the Nailed Debt
Write a past sin on paper, read verse 14 over it aloud, then destroy the paper — the debt is canceled.

In one line: All the fullness of God dwells in Christ — and in Him you are complete, forgiven, debt-free and on the winning side.